



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Course Report: Political Science Analysis SK2121 Fall semester 2025

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The course Political Science Analysis (SK2121) is a core course on the advanced level. It is the first course on the Master's Program in Political Science (MAPS) and the Master's Programme in Political Science: Environmental Governance and Behavior (MAPSE) and forms the introduction to these programmes.

Course coordinator is Frida Boräng, who is also responsible for the research area Comparative politics. The other teachers on the course are Lina Eriksson (Political theory), Victor Lapuente (Public administration) Nikolay Marinov (International politics), and Georgios Xezonakis (Political behavior). Jacob Gunderson works with academic writing support during the course, giving one lecture at the start of the course and providing individual tutorials for students seeking support.

The idea behind the course is to present an overview of Political Science. The course is organized around five research areas – Political Theory, Comparative Politics, Political Behavior, Public Administration and International Politics. Each bloc consists of three parts - a "base" lecture, two "research front" lectures, a voluntary "literature talk", and an examination seminar. The base lecture presents the background and development of the research area, as well as classical theories, concepts and findings. The research front lectures focus on selected actual research problems, based in current research. For each research area the students are presented seminar assignments in the form of three semi-selective themes or research problems which should be analyzed and discussed in a short research overview and discussed at the seminar, using the assigned literature. The examination of the course is based on each of these five papers and the seminars. There is also a voluntary literature talk between the lectures and the examining seminar, the idea being that the students would have had time to read most of the literature, but still be working on the written assignment. During the literature talks, students can come with their questions about the literature and discuss them together with fellow students and the responsible teacher.

The course is examined through five research overviews, one for each research area. In addition to the research reports the student must make one oral presentation of their research report and actively participate in all five compulsory seminars to pass the course. The five seminar papers are graded Fail (U), Pass (G), or Pass with Distinction (VG) and awarded 3 credits each. Failed seminar papers have to be completed following the teacher's instruction in order to reach the Pass level. In order to pass the course (G), the student needs to pass all the assignments. In order to pass the course with distinction (VG), at least 3 of the seminar papers must have the grade VG and the rest of the assignments have the grade G. The fall semester of 2025 marked the final offering of the course in its current format. As

part of the restructuring of the MAPS program, it will be replaced by a new 7.5-credit course, SK2122: Introduction to Political Science Analysis, which will be offered for the first time in the fall of 2026.

During the fall semester 2025, 43 students were registered on the course. Of the 43, 38 had completed the course by February 2026. 16 students received the grade Pass (G) and 22 students Pass with Distinction (VG).

The students were asked to fill in the course evaluation after the course was completed. Out of the students who received the evaluation survey, 19 students responded (43%). The survey responses are attached. In general, the students evaluated the course positively: 79% of the students assess the course as either *Very good* or *Rather good*. When asked to what degree the course helped the student to reach the learning outcomes, 32% answered *To a high degree* and 53% *To a fairly high degree*. The students also evaluated the teachers positively (*Very good* 37%, *Rather good* 47%). The organization of the course was seen as working well (*Very good* 53%, *Rather good* 37%).

A challenge for the course is the diverse educational backgrounds of the students. Typically, MAPS students have a stronger foundation in political science from their bachelor's degrees compared to MAPSE students, for whom political science is not a prerequisite. It is not obvious how to strike a balance that accommodates both groups and the course can be more challenging for students without a political science background. The comments in the survey highlight the heterogeneity of the students' educational backgrounds. For some, the course content represents new subject matter, whereas for others it serves to consolidate and extend previously acquired knowledge.

Most students were happy with the examination in the form of papers (32% *Very good*, 32% *Rather good*). Compared to previous years, the students were less enthusiastic about the lectures this time, with 50% assessing them as *Very good* or *Rather good*, which is lower than previous years. The primary criticism raised in the comments is that students would like the lectures to be more closely aligned with the assignments. Similarly the seminars (58% *Very good* or *Rather good*) and literature talks (47% *Very good* or *Rather good*) received more mixed assessments this year compared to previous years.

A recurring point of discussion regarding the examination seminars is that, because students are free to choose their paper topics, the distribution of themes – and consequently the presentations – varies across seminars (for example, there may be three presentations on the same theme and none on the other two). It appears that this time, this bottom-up, flexible structure was seen as more costly by some students, who felt that they did not learn as much as they could have if the presentations had been more varied.

When it comes to workload, 42% found it OK, but 47% thought it was somewhat or much too demanding while 11% found it not that demanding. At the same time, the amount of time students reported spending on the course each week varied considerably: 11% worked more than 40 hours per week, 21% reported 31–40 hours, and 42% reported 11–30 hours per week. Meanwhile, 26% indicated that they worked only 11–20 hours per week.

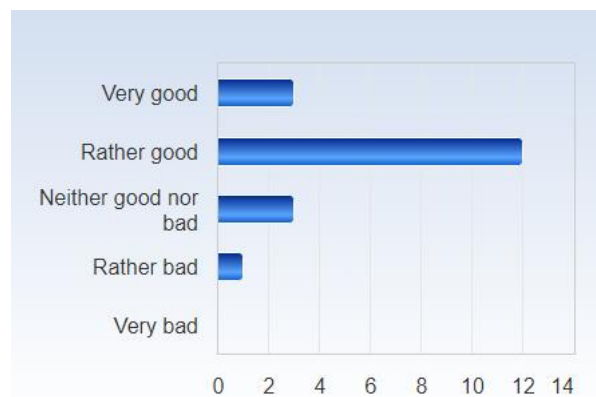
In summary, students were somewhat less enthusiastic about the course compared to previous years. Since both the course structure and the teaching staff remained the same, it is difficult to determine the reason for this difference, which may potentially be related to variations in the student cohort's preferences. It should also be noted that a clear majority of students still assess the course as very good or rather good.

SK2121 H25 Political Science Analysis

Respondents: 44
Answer Count: 19
Answer Frequency: 43.18%

Overall, how would you assess the course?

Overall, how would you assess the course?	Number of responses
Very good	3 (15.8%)
Rather good	12 (63.2%)
Neither good nor bad	3 (15.8%)
Rather bad	1 (5.3%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	19 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the course?	2.1	0.7	35.0 %	1.0	2.0	2.0	2.0	4.0



After completion of the course the students are expected to reach the following learning outcomes:

Knowledge and understanding:

- have indepth as well as broad general knowledge of the main Political Science research areas**
- have gained insights of such a character that will make possible in-depth understanding and analysis of various Political Science problematics and issues by means of contending analytivcal perspectives and research methods**

Skills and abilities:

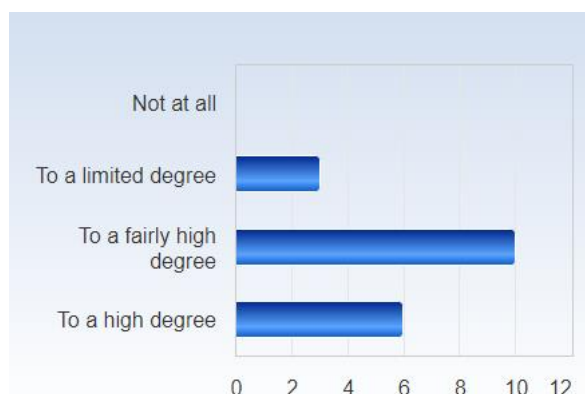
- Independently, at an in-depth level, organise, write and present orally and in writing short research reports with topics from the various Political Science research areas**

Judgement and approach:

- At an in-depth level understand and critically evaluate research based on the main Political Science research.**

To what degree the course helped you to reach these learning outcomes?

After completion of the course the students are expected to reach the following learning outcomes: Knowledge and understanding: - have indepth as well as broad general knowledge of the main Political Science research areas - have gained insights of such a character that will make possible in-depth understanding and analysis of various Political Science problematics and issues by means of contending analytival perspectives and research methods Skills and abilities: - Independently, at an in-depth level, organise, write and present orally and in writing short research reports with topics from the various Political Science research areas Judgement and approach: - At an in-depth level understand and critically evaluate research based on the main Political Science research. To what degree the course helped you to reach these learning outcomes?	Number of responses
Not at all	0 (0.0%)
To a limited degree	3 (15.8%)
To a fairly high degree	10 (52.6%)
To a high degree	6 (31.6%)
Total	19 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coef- ficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quar- tile	Median	Upper Quar- tile	Max
After completion of the course the students are expected to reach the following learning outcomes: Knowledge and understanding: - have indepth as well as broad general knowledge of the main Political Science research areas - have gained insights of such a character that will make possible in-depth understanding and analysis of various Political Science problematics and issues by means of contending analytival perspectives and research methods Skills and abilities: - Independently, at an in-depth level, organise, write and present orally and in writing short research reports with topics from the various Political Science research areas Judgement and approach: - At an in-depth level understand and critically evaluate research based on the main Political Science research. To what degree the course helped you to reach these learning outcomes?	3.2	0.7	21.8 %	2.0	3.0	3.0	4.0	4.0

Overall, how would you assess the lectures?

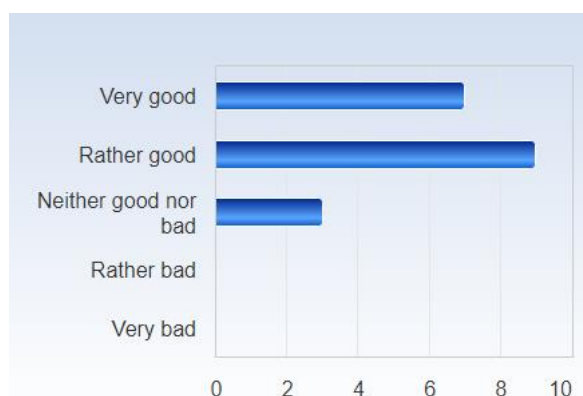
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	Number of responses
Very good	2 (11.1%)
Rather good	7 (38.9%)
Neither good nor bad	5 (27.8%)
Rather bad	4 (22.2%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	18 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	2.6	1.0	37.5 %	1.0	2.0	2.5	3.0	4.0

Overall, how would you assess the teachers?

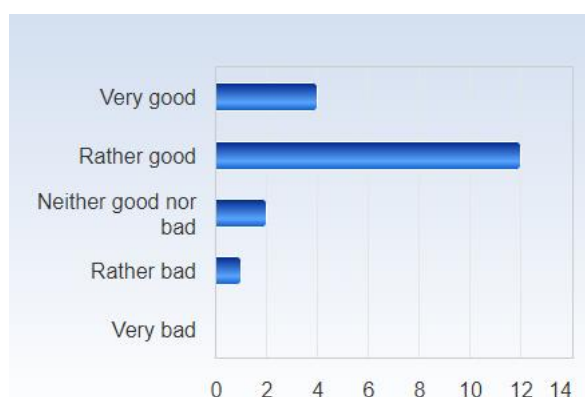
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	Number of responses
Very good	7 (36.8%)
Rather good	9 (47.4%)
Neither good nor bad	3 (15.8%)
Rather bad	0 (0.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	19 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	1.8	0.7	39.9 %	1.0	1.0	2.0	2.0	3.0

Overall, how would you assess the literature?

Overall, how would you assess the literature?	Number of responses
Very good	4 (21.1%)
Rather good	12 (63.2%)
Neither good nor bad	2 (10.5%)
Rather bad	1 (5.3%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	19 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the literature?	2.0	0.7	37.3 %	1.0	2.0	2.0	2.0	4.0

Overall, how would you assess the literature talks?

Overall, how would you assess the literature talks?	Number of responses
Very good	5 (26.3%)
Rather good	4 (21.1%)
Neither good nor bad	5 (26.3%)
Rather bad	4 (21.1%)
Very bad	1 (5.3%)
Total	19 (100.0%)

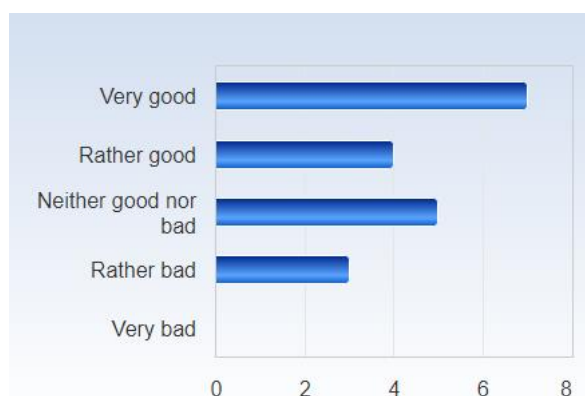


	Mean	Standard	Coefficient of	Min	Lower	Median	Upper	Max
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		Deviation	Variation		Quartile		Quartile	
Overall, how would you assess the literature talks?	2.6	1.4	52.5 %	1.0	1.5	3.0	3.5	6.0

Overall, how would you assess the seminars?

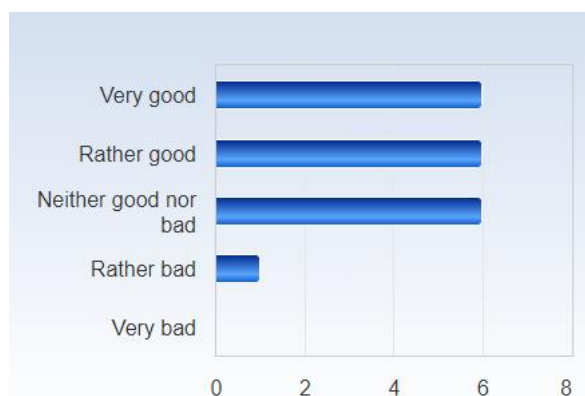
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	Number of responses
Very good	7 (36.8%)
Rather good	4 (21.1%)
Neither good nor bad	5 (26.3%)
Rather bad	3 (15.8%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	19 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	2.2	1.1	51.3 %	1.0	1.0	2.0	3.0	4.0

Overall, how would you assess the examination in form of papers?

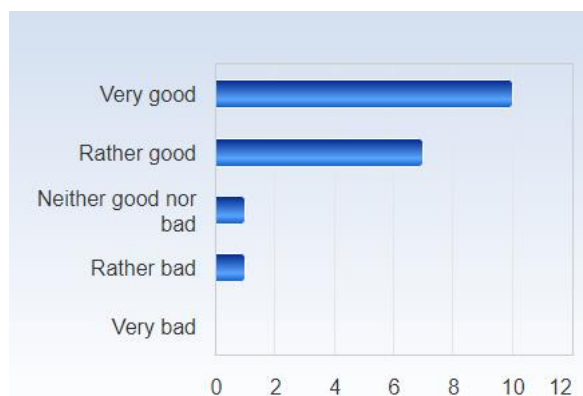
Overall, how would you assess the examination in form of papers?	Number of responses
Very good	6 (31.6%)
Rather good	6 (31.6%)
Neither good nor bad	6 (31.6%)
Rather bad	1 (5.3%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	19 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the examination in form of papers?	2.1	0.9	44.5 %	1.0	1.0	2.0	3.0	4.0

How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (information, schedule, administration)?

How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (information, schedule, administration)?	Number of responses
Very good	10 (52.6%)
Rather good	7 (36.8%)
Neither good nor bad	1 (5.3%)
Rather bad	1 (5.3%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	19 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (information, schedule, administration)?	1.6	0.8	50.9 %	1.0	1.0	1.0	2.0	4.0

What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:

What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:	Number of responses
Much too demanding	2 (10.5%)
Somewhat too demanding	7 (36.8%)
OK	8 (42.1%)
Not that demanding	2 (10.5%)
Not at all demanding	0 (0.0%)
Total	19 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:	2.5	0.8	33.3 %	1.0	2.0	3.0	3.0	4.0

On average, approximately how much time do you spend on coursework, both in and outside of the classroom, per week?

On average, approximately how much time do you spend on coursework, both in and outside of the classroom, per week?	Number of responses
Less than 10 hours	0 (0.0%)
11-20 hours	5 (26.3%)
21-30 hours	8 (42.1%)
31-40 hours	4 (21.1%)
More than 40 hours	2 (10.5%)
Total	19 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
On average, approximately how much time do you spend on coursework, both in and outside of the classroom, per week?	3.3	1.2	36.6 %	2.0	2.5	3.0	4.0	6.0